Summary: When Sexism Endangers Lives – In Israel, Sidelining Women Comes at the Cost of Security

Yofi Tirosh (Associate Professor, Tel Aviv University Faculty of Law), *Just Security*, 23 October 2025 – opinion piece

In one paragraph. Writing two years after the 7 October 2023 attack and the war in Gaza, Tirosh argues that Israel's idea of **security is too narrow** – measured only in military terms (casualties, thwarted attacks, strikes, territory) – and that a **gender-based analysis** is essential to rethinking it. A narrow "life itself" security discourse has been used to **undermine democracy, rights and "citizenship security"**, and costs women disproportionately. Excluding women from decision-making is not only unequal but **dangerous**: the warnings of female army spotters before 7 October were ignored. Wars have **built-in gendered harms** (sexual violence, harm to Gazan women, burdens on the home front), and violence against women at home is as political as war. **Note:** this is a short **opinion piece** drawing on politics, feminist theory and UN Security Council Resolution 1325 – not a technical IHL analysis.

1. Security: too much, too narrowly defined

- Israeli security discourse is framed by **military metrics**. But damage to this "narrow" security is directly linked to harm to broader **human security** – housing, employment, emotional well-being in families and schools, social welfare, and "**citizenship security**" – all of which have gendered dimensions.
- The military focus let the government **deflect attention**: hostages' families were told not to protest too loudly so as not to hinder the war aim of eliminating Hamas. Months of "abandoning" the hostages damaged Israel's **ethos of solidarity** and public trust, and silenced discussion of the **toll on Gaza's civilians**.
- Missile attacks by Hamas, Hezbollah, the Houthis and Iran shattered physical safety, but an equally serious injury is the **erosion of citizens' trust** in fair, transparent decision-making and free expression – mirroring trends in the US.
- The government's undermining of democracy (e.g. the judicial overhaul) attacks the **social contract**: the security of living in a just society with dignity and equality before the law. Palestinian citizens of Israel have long suffered such violations; **women** too, through the religious monopoly over **personal status** law and a militaristic culture; and increasingly Jewish dissenters.

2. "Life itself" as a way of undermining rights

- In 2015 Netanyahu answered criticism about housing costs by saying he did not forget "**life itself**" – the greatest challenge being Iran's nuclear programme.
- Tirosh calls this a narrow **Hobbesian** view (the ruler's only duty is to protect subjects' lives), ignoring **Locke** (liberty and property) and **Rawls** (fairness and dignity): a state's powers (sending citizens to war or prison, taxing) are legitimate only if it obeys the law and respects checks and balances.
- If an oppressive and discriminatory society takes root "under the guise of war", life itself is diminished.
- Gender analysis is routinely treated as a "**lifestyle**" topic and dropped for "real" security news – a misguided view whose disproportionate cost to women erodes **social resilience**.

3. Chauvinism endangers lives

- **UN Security Council Resolution 1325 (2000)** recognized women's role in conflict resolution – based on equality **and effectiveness**: experience in Northern Ireland, Colombia and Nigeria shows women's

participation makes peace agreements **last longer**.

- In **2005 the Knesset incorporated Resolution 1325 into Israeli law**, requiring appropriate representation of women from diverse groups on national policy committees. Governments have consistently **failed** to comply: **no woman has ever sat in Israel's war cabinet**; none on the COVID cabinet or the 2010 flotilla inquiry. Court petitions become a "cat and mouse" game (too early or too late).
- Diversity improves decisions in business too (Goldman Sachs's 2020 board policy). Attacks on diversity (e.g. Trump's attack on DEI) and hierarchies of gender, race or religion are part of the **autocratic playbook**.
- **7 October**: in the days before the attack, **female spotters** (surveillance soldiers) and a female intelligence NCO gave repeated early warnings of Hamas preparations, which were **systematically, sometimes harshly, dismissed**. Women's presence is not enough – their voices must be **taken seriously**. Excluding women also teaches children that women's voices count for less.

4. Wars have core gendered dimensions – "not a bug, a feature"

- Resolution 1325 recognized that wars harm women in distinct ways, leading to acknowledgement of **systematic rape as a deliberate war strategy** (Kosovo, Rwanda, and **7 October**) rather than incidental damage, and to legal mechanisms to prosecute **rape as a war crime** – previously dismissed as an apolitical "private" crime.
- **Gazan women** are disproportionately affected: heightened risk of **sexual and domestic violence** in evacuation zones; emotional, economic and **reproductive** harm; giving birth under fire; shortages of hygiene supplies; raising children without food or medicine; the collapse of healthcare and education – all largely unaddressed.
- **Israel's home front**: reservists' wives manage households, children and elderly parents with little support; the Treasury initially refused to compensate employees forced to stay home during the **campaign against Iran** – hitting low-paid essential workers (mostly women, e.g. cashiers) hardest.
- Example: Hillary Clinton's $14 million for **clean-water taps** in refugee camps (10th anniversary of Resolution 1325) – because women fetching water are exposed to attack. Gendered harm is **inherent in war**, not incidental.
- Children near Gaza (Sapir College) suffer bedwetting, tics, anxiety and sleep disorders from years of rockets and incendiary balloons – harms **never counted** in policymakers' cost–benefit analyses.

5. Public attention, narrative and ethos

- Catharine **MacKinnon**, the day after 9/11: around 3,000 people were murdered – a similar number of women are killed by partners each year in the US. "**This too is war**: war against women", unrecognized because it is seen as private and routine.
- Before 7 October, annual **terror-related killings** in Israel were comparable to the number of **women killed by partners or relatives**. Both are underpinned by an ideology of **masculinity**, often cloaked in religion.
- The same ideology drives the government's **rollback of women's rights**: weakening electronic monitoring of violent partners, resisting the **Istanbul Convention**, empowering rabbinical courts, promoting gender segregation in academia, halting a law on financial abuse; excluding women's NGOs from events about religious women; **strip-searching** women protesters; and **refusing women entry to public shelters** during missile attacks (shelters used as synagogues; "modesty"; men-only shelters).
- Israel has thus eroded **equal access to security** – a basic resource that should not depend on wealth, worldview or gender.

- If a fraction of the military budget and attention went to **domestic violence**…; securitist discourse shapes national identity and **legitimizes rights infringements**, relegating violence against women to secondary status even though it is **no less political**. Virginia Woolf (1940): “There are other tables besides officer tables and conference tables.”

6. Conclusion

Without a shift in perspective, Israel stays trapped “in the same destructive script”. A safer world will show itself when the media prioritize women’s equality, security and welfare; when government weighs **harm to the home front** equally with battlefield gains; and when the defence of “life itself” includes murders in **Arab communities**, **women killed at home**, and harm to civilian infrastructure, trust and human security – not only lives lost in combat or terror attacks.

Key takeaways

- **Security is broader than military security**: human security and “citizenship security” (rights, democracy, trust) are part of it – and they are gendered.
- A narrow “**life itself**” discourse (Hobbes) has been used to justify sidelining hostages’ families, civilian harm in Gaza and the erosion of democracy and rights; legitimacy requires Locke’s and Rawls’s idea of rights and checks and balances.
- **Resolution 1325** rests on equality **and effectiveness**; Israel adopted it into law in **2005** but has never put a woman in its war cabinet.
- **Sexism is a security risk**: the dismissed warnings of female spotters before 7 October show that women must not only be present but **listened to**.
- War’s gendered harms are **structural**: conflict-related **sexual violence** (including on 7 October), harm to **Gazan women** (reproductive health, displacement, domestic violence) and the unequal burden on women on the home front.
- **Violence against women at home is political** (MacKinnon): femicide rates rival terror deaths, yet receive a fraction of the attention and resources.
- Rolling back women’s rights – including **exclusion from shelters** – means **unequal access to protection** during armed conflict.
- It is an **opinion piece**: persuasive and topical, but its claims are political and should be backed up with legal sources in an essay.

Why this article is relevant to this week’s topic

Status of persons in armed conflict

- It gives a **current, real-world case** (7 October and the Gaza war) for the categories in IHL: **civilians** in Gaza and southern Israel, **hostages** (hostage-taking is prohibited by CA3, GC IV Art. 34 and custom), **reservists** and soldiers, and the women spotters (members of the armed forces, i.e. **combatants**).
- It shows that persons with the same legal status (civilians) **experience war differently according to gender** – women in Gaza face specific risks (childbirth, displacement, sexual and domestic violence) that IHL addresses only in limited ways (e.g. GC IV Arts. 14, 16, 23, 27; AP I Arts. 70, 76), echoing the critique in Durham & O’Byrne that IHL protects women mainly as mothers.
- Refusing women access to **shelters** raises the IHL and human rights principle of **non-discrimination** (“without adverse distinction founded on sex”) in the protection of civilians.
- It links status to **civil defence and the home front** – the protection of civilians from the effects of hostilities is a duty owed to everyone equally.

Direct participation in hostilities

- The article does **not** discuss DPH directly, but it connects to it in three ways.
- **Women in the armed forces**: the female spotters were soldiers performing intelligence and surveillance – a role that, if done by civilians, would be a classic DPH example (transmitting tactical targeting intelligence, ICRC Guidance). It shows women are **integral to military operations**, against the stereotype of women as civilians only.
- **Narrow framing of who matters**: Tirosh criticizes measuring war only by battlefield results – similarly, the DPH debate is about not treating everyone connected to the enemy (including women in support roles) as targetable. Ignoring civilian harm in Gaza connects to the importance of distinction, precautions and the presumption of civilian status.
- **7 October**: Hamas fighters and others who crossed the border were participating in hostilities; the deliberate killing, abduction and sexual violence against civilians are **war crimes** regardless of the attackers' status.

Gender and law

- It applies the **Women, Peace and Security agenda** (Resolution 1325 and its follow-ups) to a live conflict, and shows the gap between **law on paper** (Israel's 2005 law) and **practice** (no women in the war cabinet) – a useful example for discussing the effectiveness of soft law, which Durham & O'Byrne also raise.
- It treats **sexual violence as a strategy of war** (Kosovo, Rwanda, 7 October) and links it to the development of rape as a war crime – connecting to *Akayesu*, *Kunarac* and the Rome Statute.
- It brings in **feminist legal theory** (MacKinnon; the public/private divide; masculinity as a driver of violence) and the critique that security is defined from a male perspective – a strong argument for "gender mainstreaming" in IHL and security policy.
- It connects IHL with **human rights and domestic law** (Istanbul Convention, personal status law, protest rights), showing that gendered harm in war continues on the home front and after the fighting.
- Read critically: it focuses on Israel's internal politics and is written from a particular political viewpoint; for an IHL essay, pair it with the legal framework (Durham & O'Byrne, the ICRC DPH Guidance, GC IV) rather than relying on it alone.